

those rolls of paper towels? Isn't it more prudent to use rags? I relish their wide-eyed look at the low final total after my coupons are deducted and it dawns on them that those products were totally free after coupon savings. The media loves the "wow" factor, and the audience doesn't disappoint with their incredulous reaction to the "Coupon Queen's" fabulous savings.

But I'm not always walking out of stores with carts full of free merchandise. Outside of the set up shopping trip and rare double coupon opportunities, I might only save a meager 10 to 20 percent off my grocery bill and 80 percent on my health and beauty purchases, still well above the average coupon user's savings.

According to research done by the Promotion Marketing Association (PMA) a typical coupon user reports an average of 7 percent savings on their weekly grocery bills. In a September 2008 press release, the PMA reported that consumers who spend just twenty minutes per week clipping and organizing their coupons can save up to one thousand dollars a year on their annual grocery bill. The typical family saves between five and nine dollars per week using coupons. Forty-six percent of consumers spend just ten minutes clipping and organizing and still achieve an average of seven dollars a week in savings.

Reporter Brett Arends did the math in a February, 2010 *Wall Street Journal* article, figuring that with an average value of \$1.44 per coupon and a minute's effort to clip, the savings is the equivalent of \$14.40 per ten minutes, or \$86.40 per hour. And unlike money earned at work, the coupon savings is tax free.